

A Forgotten Forest Experiment Grew Giant Trees

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How should people take care of a forest? In Australia, people have argued about this for decades. Some want forests fully protected. Others want trees harvested for wood to support local jobs. A long-forgotten experiment suggests there may be a middle path.

In the late 1980s, the government of the Australian state of Victoria set up a big experiment in its **mountain ash** forests. **Mountain ash** trees are among the tallest trees in the world. Scientists tried different ways of harvesting. Some areas were clearfelled, meaning every tree in a block was cut down. Others had small patches cleared. In "heavily thinned" areas, 50 to 70 percent of the trees were cut, and the rest were left standing. Some forest was left untouched for comparison.

After early results were published, the experiment was forgotten. The access road grew over and the project sign fell down. Then, in 2014, researchers from the University of Melbourne visited the site with students and were amazed by what they found.

The trees left behind in the thinned areas had grown enormous, with more space and resources to share. The largest averaged more than a meter across and were 20 percent wider than the biggest trees in untouched forest. Even more surprising, the thinned forest had stored as much carbon in its wood as the untouched forest, or more.

Bigger trees are more likely to survive fires and to form **hollows**, where rare animals such as the greater glider live. **Camera traps** found endangered Leadbeater's possums in every harvested plot the team surveyed, but none in the untouched areas.

The researchers say careful **thinning** could provide wood, store carbon and help wildlife at the same time, though it should not be done everywhere.

Word Treasure

clearfelling -- Cutting down every tree in a block of forest.

thinning -- Cutting some trees so the remaining trees have more room.

mountain ash -- A very tall Australian tree.

camera trap -- A hidden camera that takes pictures when animals pass.

hollow -- A hole inside a tree where animals can live.

Break it down

Lead: a debate over managing forests

The 1980s experiment and its methods

The experiment is forgotten, then rediscovered in 2014

Huge trees and carbon results

Benefits for rare wildlife

Researchers' conclusion and its limits

Why it matters

The findings suggest forests can be managed to provide wood, store carbon and support wildlife at the same time, which could inform decisions about forests.

Test what you remember

1. What two sides have Australians argued about?
 - (A) Fully protecting forests or harvesting trees for wood
 - (B) Hunting or fishing
 - (C) Planting flowers or grass
 - (D) Building roads or railways
2. Which Australian state set up the experiment?
 - (A) New South Wales
 - (B) Victoria
 - (C) Queensland
 - (D) Tasmania
3. What happened to the access road and project sign after the early results?
 - (A) They became a museum
 - (B) They were rebuilt in gold
 - (C) The road grew over and the sign fell down
 - (D) They were moved to the city
4. How much wider were the largest thinned trees than the biggest untouched-forest trees?
 - (A) 20 percent
 - (B) 200 percent
 - (C) 2 percent
 - (D) They were narrower
5. Why are bigger trees helpful for wildlife?
 - (A) They grow fruit all year
 - (B) They make more noise
 - (C) They are more likely to form hollows where rare animals live
 - (D) They scare away predators
6. What do the researchers say about thinning?
 - (A) It could help wood, carbon and wildlife but should not be done everywhere
 - (B) It always harms animals
 - (C) It should replace all forests
 - (D) It has never been tested

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: C 4: A 5: C 6: A

Questions to think about

1. The University of Melbourne researchers: Say careful thinning could provide wood, store carbon and help wildlife, but should not be used everywhere.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):